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FEATURED

Neighbors speak up, city listens at Downing's Ward 1 town hall

From roads to redevelopment, Anniston residents bring concerns — and ideas — to the table

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Councilman Lewis Downing addresses residents during a Ward 1 town hall meeting Thursday night at the Anniston Museum of Natural History, where city officials fielded questions on roads, trash, development and public safety.

At a glance



— More than 40 residents attended Ward 1 Councilman Lewis Downing’s town hall, joining top city leaders to discuss roads, trash, noise and growth.

— Officials outlined a potential \$10-\$12.5 million paving plan, guided by traffic and need, with a long-term maintenance strategy to follow.

— Conversations ranged from stray animals to McClellan development and future data centers, reflecting shared concerns across Anniston neighborhoods.

ANNISTON — Attracting more than 40 residents to the auditorium at the Anniston Museum of Natural History, Ward 1 Councilman Lewis Downing’s town hall meeting Thursday evening offered a lively and candid look at the concerns shaping daily life across the city.

City leaders — including the mayor, city manager, police chief and department heads — joined Downing for the hour-and-a-half session, fielding questions on everything from potholes to potential economic development. The meeting marked the final installment in a series of town halls held by council members this year, aimed at strengthening communication with residents. Anniston Mayor Ciara Smith-Roston said there will be a “state of the city” in May or June to update residents on ongoing projects, the city’s vision and where the city is headed.

Roads and long-term planning

Road conditions quickly emerged as a top concern, echoing conversations from previous meetings.

Smith-Roston said the city is preparing a comprehensive paving strategy after a 2020 assessment.

“So back in 2020 we completed a road assessment ... and as you can imagine, the majority of the roads in Anniston were between four and five,” she said, five representing the worst condition. “We were able to complete over 30 pavement projects ... but funds are limited.”

The city is now working with an engineering consultant to develop a five- to seven-year paving plan, potentially backed by a bond ranging from \$10 million to \$12.5 million.

“We can’t cherry-pick which roads we’re going to do,” Smith-Roston said. “It’s going to be assessed based on how many people travel that road, how many people live on that road.”

Downing emphasized that outside expertise will help guide spending decisions.

“A municipal consultant will help us determine the most efficient and effective use of those dollars,” he said. “Obviously, we can’t pave everything ... but they will help us determine which options are most effective.”

Trash, debris and animal concerns

Concerns about trash and illegal dumping sparked one of the evening's most animated discussions.

Residents described persistent litter problems that attract rodents — and, in some cases, stray cats.

"This is a very common issue for us," Downing said. "You have a trash problem, we have a trash problem, and that breeds a rodent problem, and that breeds a feline problem."

Interim City Manager Matt Caballero acknowledged limitations in animal control services, noting the city currently lacks capacity to house cats.

Public Works Director David Arnett broke down how waste collection operates, emphasizing the importance of residents disposing of their household garbage in the cleanest manner feasible.

"Biggest thing to take away from trash ... put everything in a bag," Arnett said. "If it's not in a bag ... it goes like confetti ... and they're going to leave all that paper in your yard."

He encouraged residents to use the city's website or call to submit work orders, adding that more detailed reports help crews respond faster. He also mentioned that the city's private collection company, 121, uses cameras on its trucks to keep a visual record of whether a pickup was missed.

Noise, traffic and lighting

Noise complaints — particularly regarding cargo trucks using their jake brakes on the eastern bypass hill — also drew attention.

"We can't enjoy our backyard," one Lakeshore Drive resident said, noting that the neighborhood there existed decades before the bypass came along.

Downing said a past state study did not find significant noise issues but said the city could revisit the concern.

“That doesn’t mean that’s not something that we can reach out to the Department of Transportation and discuss,” he said.

Residents also raised concerns about loud vehicles and drag racing on public roads; modern exhaust modifications on cars and motorcycles allow their roar to be heard inside homes a half-mile or more away. The noise is particularly noticeable on weekend evenings during nice weather. But, Caballero said, enforcement is limited by state law and depends largely on officers catching violations in real time.

“If you hear that and it seems like it’s an all-day thing, call the police department and ask them to put in extra patrols,” he said.

The discussion expanded to include calls for improved lighting in areas such as McClellan and Golden Springs. One example of hazardous darkness cited was the section of bypass starting at the Golden Springs intersection northbound.

McClellan development and growth

Questions about the future of McClellan highlighted both progress and uncertainty.

Downing said the city has taken control of most public property at the site and is focused on attracting large-scale development.

“We are actively entertaining offers for land out there for larger developments,” said Aaron Norris, director of economic development and city planning. “We’re not currently entertaining offers for single-family residences.”

Downing added that residential development could begin within 12 to 18 months, though the city is prioritizing projects that expand the tax base.

Looking ahead: data centers and studios

Residents also asked about the possibility of artificial intelligence data centers locating in Anniston.

Downing said such interest could come in the future, citing the city’s available resources, but urged caution.

“I think that any smart governing body would have grave concerns ... especially with an industry as young as AI and data centers,” he said.

Smith-Roston echoed that sentiment.

“I don’t think that Anniston currently is in the position to discuss actually having a data center here,” she said. “We need to further understand how that impacts our communities.”

On a more immediate front, the mayor shared an update on redevelopment of the former Starships property at McClellan into a studio project. Construction is underway, though the effort is expected to unfold over several years.

Public transportation and communication

Public transportation access also surfaced as a concern, with one resident noting limited visibility of services in her neighborhood.

Downing said the East Alabama Regional Planning and Development Commission operates transit across the county and encouraged residents to connect directly for assistance.

Throughout the evening, officials repeatedly emphasized communication — whether through council members, city departments or online tools — as key to addressing concerns. Public information officer Jackson Hodges demonstrated use of the city’s website as a means for the public to relay concerns and ask questions of city leaders.

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